



The Platform Society

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CHAPTER

Introduction

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Abstract

The introduction puts forward the notion of the “platform society,” which emphasizes the inextricable relation between online platforms and societal structures. It refers to a society in which social and economic traffic is increasingly channeled by a (corporate) global online platform ecosystem that is driven by algorithms and fueled by data. In turn, an online platform should be understood as a programmable digital architecture designed to organize interactions between users—not just end users but also corporate entities and public bodies. It is geared toward the systematic collection, algorithmic processing, circulation, and monetization of user data. Crucially, platforms cannot be seen apart from each other but evolve in the context of an online setting that is structured by its own logic.

Keywords: [platform society](#), [online platform](#), [platform revolution](#), [infrastructural service](#), [sectoral platform](#)

Subject: [Economics](#), [Digital Lifestyle](#), [Media Studies](#)

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THE “SHARING ECONOMY,” the “platform revolution,” the “gig economy,” “disruptive innovation”—these are just a handful of epithets used to denote the latest transformation of the Internet. The rise of digital platforms is hailed as the driver of economic progress and technological innovation. Individuals can greatly benefit from this transformation because it empowers them to set up businesses, trade goods, and exchange information online while circumventing corporate or state intermediaries. People all over the world can use Airbnb to rent an apartment in a foreign city, check Coursera to find a course on statistics, join PatientsLikeMe to exchange information about one’s disease, hail a ride using Uber, read news through Facebook’s Instant Articles or use Deliveroo to have food delivered to their homes. In doing so, users can avoid booking a regular hotel, registering at a university, going to a general practitioner, calling a licensed taxi business, buying a newspaper, or visiting a restaurant. The promise of platforms is that they offer personalized services and contribute to innovation and economic growth, while efficiently bypassing incumbent organizations, cumbersome regulations, and unnecessary expenses.

Some management and business scholars have touted this development the “platform revolution” and focus on the positive economic effects of a technological development they hail as “innovative disruption” (Parker, Van Alstyne, Choudary 2016; Sundararajan 2016). Individual citizens or consumers organize themselves through online networks, so they are less dependent on legacy institutions or companies such as publishers, news organizations, hospitals, unions, brokers, and so on. The Internet-based utopian marketplace would allow individuals to offer products or services “directly” without having to rely on “offline” intermediaries, whether state or corporate. In the early years of this development, some theorists touted the nascent growth of online platforms as the economic corollary of a “participatory culture” that started with the emergence of social media networks and Web 2.0 in the early years of the millennium (Archibugi, Filippetti, and Frenz 2013; Jenkins, Ford, and Green 2013; Aigrain 2012; Botsman and Rogers 2010b; Bruns, 2008; Leadbeater 2009). The wealth of online social networks enables connectedness, while bypassing existing social institutions; following this line of argument, *connectivity* automatically leads to *collectivity* or connectedness.

We agree that online platforms are at the core of an important development, but we think of them neither as an exclusive economic phenomenon nor as a technological construct with social corollaries. Rather, we prefer a comprehensive view of a connective world where platforms have penetrated the heart of societies—affecting institutions, economic transactions, and social and cultural practices—hence forcing governments and states to adjust their legal and democratic structures (Chadwick 2013; Van Dijck 2013). Platforms, in our view, do not *cause* a revolution; instead, they are gradually infiltrating in, and converging with, the (offline, legacy) institutions and practices through which democratic societies are organized. That is why we prefer the term “platform society”—a term that emphasizes the inextricable relation between online platforms and societal structures. Platforms do not reflect the social: they *produce* the social structures we live in (Couldry and Hepp 2016).

The “platform society” does not merely shift the focus from the economic to the social; the term also refers to a profound dispute about private gain versus public benefit in a society where most interactions are carried out via the Internet. While platforms allegedly enhance personalized benefits and economic gain, they simultaneously put pressure on collective means and public services. Airbnb offers the potential for some individuals to make some money on a spare room and for others to stay in relatively cheap accommodation. But who will pay for the collective costs? Who will enforce fire safety rules? And who will clean the streets after tourists have left? Students are tempted to consume “free” courses on Coursera, but who pays for the teaching effort that goes into producing them? We are often made to think that platforms offer a new societal arrangement, which stands apart from existing social and legal structures. The term “platform society” emphasizes that platforms are an *integral* part of society, where conflicts of interest are currently played out at various levels. We want to highlight how the implementation of platforms in society triggers a fierce discussion about private benefit and corporate gain versus public interests and collective benefits. It is a discussion that is long overdue; many platforms have grown surprisingly influential before a real debate about public values and common goods could get started.

The subtitle of the book indicates the broader perspective we assume: *what role do online platforms play in the organization of public values in North American and western European societies?* Platforms are neither neutral nor value-free constructs; they come with specific norms and values inscribed in their architectures. These norms may or may not clash with values engraved in the societal structures in which platforms vie to become (or are already) implemented. European societies are rooted in different ideological values from those introduced by many platforms. Many people consider innovation and economic progress to be the primary drivers of a platform-based society. But there are other public values at stake in the process to transfer social traffic and economic transactions to an online connective world. Some of these values have already received much attention, such as privacy, accuracy, safety, and consumer protection. We want medical apps to be accurate and hence safe for users; consumers want to keep some data private, and they want their files and photos to be protected against hackers, fraudulent users, and cyberattacks. Other values that pertain to the common good

and society as a whole are just as important—think of fairness, equality, solidarity, accountability, transparency, and democratic control. We want online education to be fair and nondiscriminatory, we want personalized health apps to contribute to equality in treatment, and we may expect from online news sites that they not only deliver accurate reports but also support democratic openness.

The connective qualities of online platforms, however, do not automatically translate into public values. Privacy issues have been a bone of contention between platform owners, state regulators, watchdog organizations, citizens, and lawyers; and they need to be assessed contextually—that means, in the specific context of each application in each social situation in each specific sector (Nissenbaum 2010). For instance, the need for transparency of data flows is important to help law enforcement but may clash with the privacy protection of users or with other public values such as security, discrimination, or taxing duties. Such conflicts may bring to the surface ideological differences between American and European democracies. Whereas many platforms, particularly the dominant ones, are US-owned and operated, European public values are often at odds with the values inscribed in their architectures. Different public values are deployed as strategic arguments in the negotiations between Airbnb owners and local city councils, between Uber and (supra-)national governments—not just in Europe but across the world. None of these values are chiseled in stone or uncontroversial; on the contrary, they are the very *stakes* in the struggle over the organization of platform societies around the globe.

The Platform Society: A Few Definitions and a Quick Reading Guide

The first chapter will lay out why the “platform society” is a contested concept, using Airbnb as an example. The term refers to **a society in which social and economic traffic is increasingly channeled by an (overwhelmingly corporate) global online platform ecosystem that is driven by algorithms and fueled by data.** To get a firm grasp of what is at stake here, we will define and unravel what we mean when we talk about “platform” and “platform ecosystem”—essentially metaphorical constructs which have become accepted as catch-all terms.¹ An online “platform” is a programmable digital architecture designed to organize interactions between users—not just end users but also corporate entities and public bodies. It is geared toward the systematic collection, algorithmic processing, circulation, and monetization of user data. Single platforms cannot be seen apart from each other but evolve in the context of an online setting that is structured by its own logic. A “platform ecosystem” is an assemblage of networked platforms, governed by a particular set of mechanisms (explained in chapter 2) that shapes everyday practices. The Western ecosystem is mostly operated by a handful of big tech companies (Alphabet-Google, Apple, Facebook, Amazon, and Microsoft) whose *infrastructural* services are central to the ecosystem’s overall design and the distribution of data flows. Besides, we will explain how several types of *sectoral platforms* are developed that often seamlessly integrate with the infrastructural core, not just in market sectors such as transport and hospitality but also in public sectors such as education and health.

Although large platforms, particularly those wielded by the “Big Five” tech companies, may dominate the ecosystem, they are not the only contestants. Governments, incumbent (small and large) businesses, individual entrepreneurs, nongovernmental organizations, cooperatives, consumers, and citizens all participate in shaping the platform society’s economic and social practices. Evidently, clashes among actors who all have their own interests take place at various levels: local, national, supranational, and global. Local governments around the world are increasingly confronted with **global platforms operating in a gray legal area.** The new ecosystem of platforms is distinctly global, and the confrontations that play out at national or local levels are symptomatic of a geopolitical minefield where ideological viewpoints are constantly clashing—particularly in Europe.

While the first chapter theorizes the platform society’s organization from a political economy perspective, the second chapter concentrates on the mechanisms platforms inject into social and economic interaction. We

have identified three main mechanisms as driving forces underlying the ecosystem: datafication, commodification, and selection. Far from being mere technical or economic processes, ↪ we emphasize the mutual shaping of technology, economic models, and users: while platform mechanisms filter and steer social interactions, users also define their outcome.² Understanding the platform society requires a thorough analysis of the ecosystem's dynamics and the techno-economic and sociocultural practices through which they take shape.

As said, the rise of the “platform society” can be characterized as a series of confrontations between different value systems, contesting the balance between private and public interests. Chapters 3 through 6 turn the spotlight on four different sectors of society, ranging from predominantly market-ruled sectors to largely public sectors, asking: *how are platforms and their mechanisms implemented in various private and public sectors in societies on both sides of the Atlantic?* It is very difficult, if not impossible, these days to make a clear-cut distinction between the private and public spheres (Dulong de Rosnay and De Martin 2012). Therefore, we concentrate on how public *values* are contested during the implementation of platforms in each sector, whether predominantly public or private. In fact, a process of privatization often forms the core of these contestations. Each of these four chapters presents a critical inquiry into the premises, practices, and conflicting interests that platforms bring to existing social structures. We explain how online platforms penetrate a specific sector, how infrastructural and sectoral platforms are embedded in the ecosystem as a whole, **which (public) values are championed or embattled**, how terms for implementation are negotiated, and how they impact the organization of sectors and societies.

Chapter 3 covers the sector of news and journalism. Predominantly a market sector, news indisputably embodies a profound public concern. Key values such as journalistic independence and the provision of trustworthy and comprehensive news reporting have come under mounting public scrutiny as connective platforms have come to steer the conditions of production and distribution. In chapter 4, the focus will shift to the market sector of urban transport, which has been shaken up in many cities around the world by ride-hailing services like Uber and Lyft. We deliberately broaden the focus from taxi services to urban transport as such, a sector rife with private as well as public interests. Chapter 5 investigates the health sector, which is strongly impacted by platforms. Most pressing in the burgeoning field of health and fitness apps are questions of safety, privacy, and accuracy, which may be squarely at odds with public values such as accessibility to data for research purposes. **Chapter 6 concentrates on education by zooming in on data-based online platforms in primary schooling and higher education in the United States and Europe.** What effect does the implementation of platforms have on public values, ranging from privacy to accessibility and *Bildung*?

In chapter 7, we will shift our focus from the analytical to the normative and return to the main issue of this book: *who is or should be responsible and accountable for* ↪ *anchoring public values in the platform society?* The responsibility for a balanced platform society—an open society that anchors its public values in a transparent and accountable manner—rests with all actors involved in its construction: corporations, governments, and civil society actors. While all three are needed to achieve such balance, we will argue that supranational, national, and local governments have a special responsibility in this regard. Particularly in the European context, governments are not just arbiters of market dynamics and level playing fields but can and should be proactive in negotiating public values on behalf of citizens and consumers. Discussing their potential roles, we argue how governments need to adjust their instrumentation for regulation and control to protect a democratically agreed upon set of public values. Finally, it is essential not only to understand the platform society's guiding mechanisms but also to link these to an ideological model in which (European) governments acknowledge their differences with the (US) values inscribed in the architecture of a global platform ecosystem. Platform societies, after all, are not insulated from geopolitical influences; the dynamics of various colluding ecosystems prompt us to look beyond the level of national battles. This global contest is not anywhere near to being settled; on the contrary, it is in full swing.

Perhaps two disclaimers are in place here. Although we try in this book to provide a comprehensive view on the complex issue of negotiating public value in a connective world, *The Platform Society* cannot offer a blueprint of what this world should look like or how academics can solve all kinds of intricate problems that come along with platformization. More than anything, our effort is a multidisciplinary attempt to draw together insights not only from science and technology studies, political economy, and business and management studies but also from media studies and legal studies. Needless to say, we cannot possibly cover all relevant scholarly angles and approaches in one book. We apologize for not being experts in all academic disciplines as we feel most at home on our own turf: media studies. In its omnivorous capacity, however, this book should offer other disciplines food for thought and engagement.

The other disclaimer concerns our object of research which is a moving target. By the time this book is out in print, there will undoubtedly have been new revelations or developments that impact the position of platforms in the digital world order. We can impossibly include or anticipate all the latest “trending topics” in our study, so we concentrate primarily on analyzing and unraveling the underpinning mechanisms of the platform ecosystem. In doing so, we hope to give students and academics an instrumentarium that helps understanding and shaping the platform society.

Notes

1. Tarleton Gillespie (2010) was the first to theorize “platform” as a metaphor with an expansive set of layered meanings, including its technical, metaphorical, political, and physical aspects. More recently, Gillespie (2017) further elaborates on this metaphor, arguing why it is at once inevitable and misleading. Although the term highlights certain aspects of online services (equality, openness, sturdiness), “platforms” dangerously downplays others (they are not flat, they are populated by diverse communities, and they elude questions of responsibility). The first chapter will reflect on the “in-betweenness” and hybridity of the platform concept.
2. “Users” is a very general term that not only refers to end users of platforms but more broadly includes any entity that is facilitated by platforms to produce, consume, or aggregate content or services; so businesses and institutions can also be touted as “users.” The term is also (intentionally) vague in referring simultaneously to consumers, citizens, (micro-)entrepreneurs, etc. In the remainder of this book, we will not bracket the word “user”; but in various chapters, we will reflect on its strategic vagueness.